

## Woman at the helm: On the new IOC president Kirsty Coventry

The new IOC president will have to **navigate** the **labyrinth** of world sports

**The first African and the first woman head** of the largest, most powerful sporting organisation on the planet, Kirsty Coventry, 41, **broke new ground** in more ways than one when she formally **took charge** of the International Olympic Committee (IOC) on Monday (June 23, 2025). Also the youngest president since Pierre de Coubertin, the founding father of the modern Olympic Games, and **hand-picked** by **outgoing** IOC president Thomas Bach, Kirsty was largely seen as a symbol of continuity with Bach, now IOC **honorary** president for life, remaining the power centre. But in the last three months since her election, the handover period, those working with her at the IOC headquarters in Lausanne shared the belief that she was her own person. While there is **likely** to be continuity in some areas, Kirsty's **experiences**, as a white woman athlete in **racially tense** Zimbabwe under Robert Mugabe and a Minister in Emmerson Mnangagwa's cabinet, **indicate** that she is **likely** to be a lot more **consensual** and **humane** when compared to the **strict** Bach. It means that she is **unlikely** to **rush into** decisions on complex issues be it protecting female athletes, transgenders in women's sports, the **scourge** of **doping**, the **relevance** of the Olympic movement, attracting new sponsors and maintaining a balance between traditional competitive sports and experimenting to bring in new audiences, something that has not always worked, as **evident** with **breakdancing** in Paris.

**Off the field**, it will be an **eventful** eight years for one of Africa's most **decorated** Olympians. There will be big decisions to make including the possible return of Russia to the Olympic **fold**. **In the run-up** to the 2028 Olympics in Los Angeles, she will have to **deal with** U.S. President Donald Trump a lot more. The political **uncertainties** and global conflicts will force her to do a lot more than **administering** only world sports. The Russia-Ukraine war and growing **hostilities** in West Asia could **have a bearing on** the hosting rights for the 2036 Olympics, something that also brings Indian interests into the **equation**. On Monday, IOC member Nita Ambani was among the closest **allies** of Kirsty during and after the formal ceremony. A two-day **closed-door session** with IOC members to exchange ideas and opinions **will** be crucial to **gauge** initial impressions. The political **situation**, in the immediate **context**, **may** also have a bearing on the possible **bids** by Qatar and Saudi Arabia, two countries with **deeper pockets** than any and with growing interest to host the Games. With little experience in navigating the complex administrative labyrinth of world sports, Kirsty would be hoping to **make a splash** with her **dive into the deep end**.

[Practice Exercise]

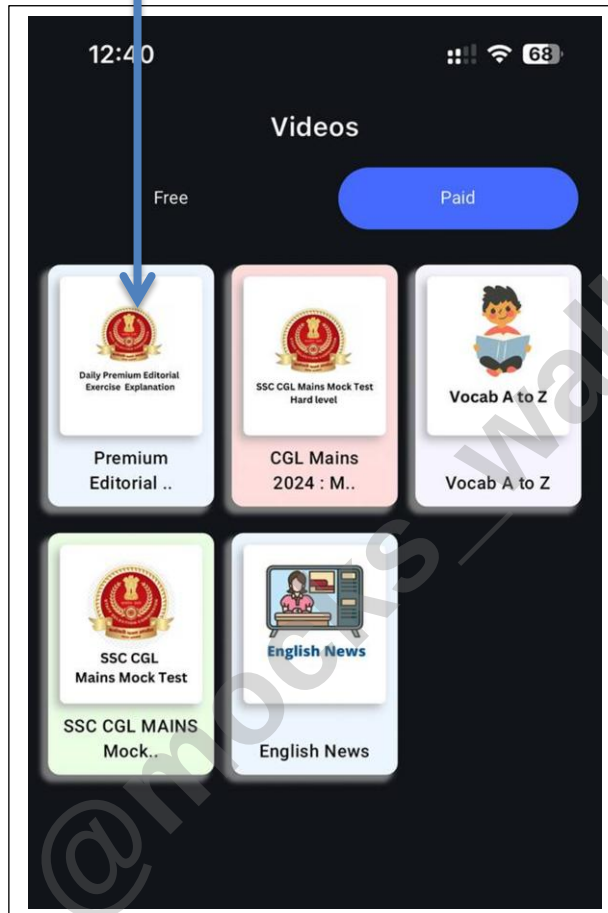
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

## Vocabulary

1. **At the helm** (phrase) – in control, in command, in charge, at the top, leading  
नेतृत्व में
2. **Navigate** (verb) – steer, manage, direct, pilot,  
guide दिशा निर्देश देना
3. **Labyrinth** (noun) – maze, network, tangle,  
web, complexity भूल-भुलैया
4. **Break new ground** (phrase) – do something  
innovative that is regarded as an advance or  
of positive benefit. नवाचार करना
5. **Take charge** (phrase) – assume control, step  
up, command, oversee, be responsible  
नियंत्रण संभालना
6. **Hand-picked** (adjective) – selected, chosen,  
appointed, nominated, designated चुना हुआ
7. **Outgoing** (adjective) – retiring, departing,  
leaving, former, past पदत्याग कर रहा
8. **Honorary** (adjective) – (of a person) holding  
an honorary title or position माननीय
9. **Likely** (adjective) – probable, expected,  
possible, anticipated, foreseeable संभावित
10. **Racially** (adverb) – ethnically, in terms of  
race, culturally, segregationally नस्लीय रूप से
11. **Tense** (adjective) – strained, stressed,  
anxious, volatile, uneasy तनावपूर्ण
12. **Consensual** (adjective) – mutual, agreed,  
collective, cooperative, harmonious सहमति  
से किया गया
13. **Humane** (adjective) – compassionate, kind,  
gentle, merciful, empathetic मानवीय
14. **Strict** (adjective) – harsh, rigid, firm,  
authoritarian, uncompromising सख्त
15. **Unlikely** (adjective) – improbable, doubtful,  
uncertain, far-fetched, implausible असंभावित
16. **Rush into** (phrasal verb) – hurry, plunge into,  
act hastily, dive into, proceed quickly  
जल्दबाजी करना
17. **Scourge** (noun) – menace, curse, affliction,  
plague, blight अभिशाप
18. **Doping** (noun) – the unlawful use of drugs to  
enhance or inhibit the performance of an  
athlete, racehorse, or greyhound. डोपिंग
19. **Relevance** (noun) – importance, significance,  
applicability, pertinence, value प्रासंगिकता
20. **Evident** (adjective) – obvious, clear,  
apparent, noticeable, manifest स्पष्ट
21. **Breakdancing** (noun) – an energetic style of  
dance typically performed to hip-hop music,  
characterized by stylized footwork and  
acrobatic or athletic movements. ब्रेकडांसिंग

22. **Off the field** (phrase) – beyond competition, outside of sports action, in non-sporting matters मैदान के बाहर
23. **Eventful** (adjective) – action-packed, momentous, significant, full of incidents घटनापूर्ण
24. **Decorated** (adjective) – awarded, honored, recognized, acclaimed, medaled सम्मानित
25. **Fold** (noun) – group, circle, association, collective, membership समूह
26. **In the run-up to** (phrase) – leading to, prior to, ahead of, approaching से पहले
27. **Deal with** (phrasal verb) – handle, manage, address, tackle, respond to निपटना
28. **Uncertainty** (noun) – unpredictability, doubt, instability, risk, insecurity अनिश्चितता
29. **Administer** (verb) – manage, govern, oversee, supervise, conduct प्रशासन करना
30. **Hostility** (noun) – conflict, enmity, tension, animosity, aggression शत्रुता
31. **Have a bearing on** (phrase) – affect, influence, impact, relate to, determine प्रभाव डालना
32. **Equation** (noun) – situation, scenario, context, relationship, dynamics समीकरण
33. **Ally** (noun) – supporter, friend, associate, partner, collaborator सहयोगी
34. **Closed-door** (adjective) – private, confidential, exclusive, secret बंद दरवाज़ों के पीछे
35. **Gauge** (verb) – assess, measure, evaluate, estimate, determine मूल्यांकन करना
36. **Context** (noun) – situation, background, setting, conditions, environment संदर्भ
37. **Bid** (noun) – proposal, offer, application, attempt, campaign बोली / प्रस्ताव
38. **Deep pocket** (noun) – A person or organization has a lot of money to spend भारी संपत्ति
39. **Make a splash** (phrase) – attract attention, make an impression, cause a stir, stand out बहुत अधिक ध्यान आकर्षित करना
40. **Dive into the deep end** (phrase) – a situation in which a person must face a difficult problem or undertaking with little or no preparation or prior experience. कठिन परिस्थिति में कूदना

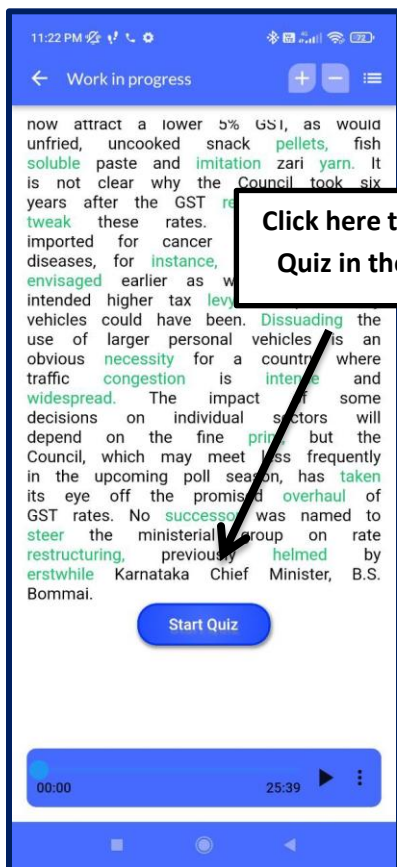
**Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.**



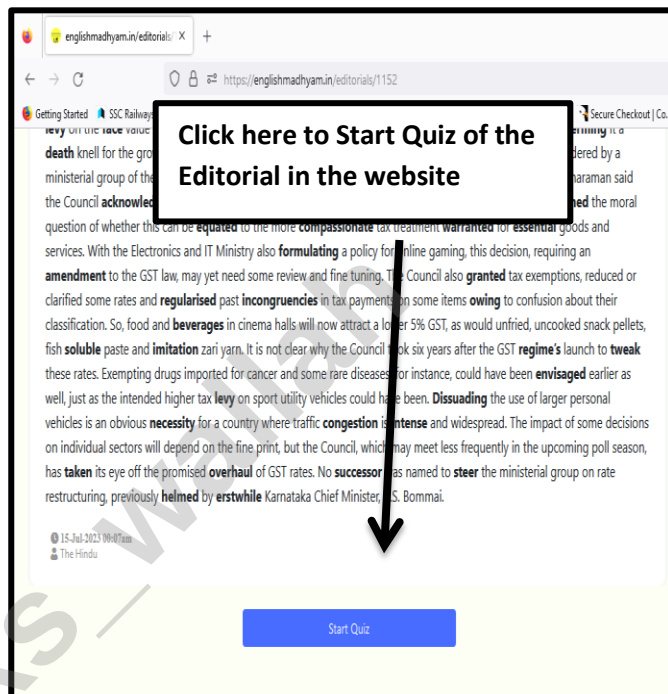
### Summary of the Editorial

1. Kirsty Coventry made history as the first African and first woman to become president of the International Olympic Committee (IOC).
2. At 41, she is also the youngest IOC president since its founder Pierre de Coubertin.
3. Coventry was hand-picked by outgoing president Thomas Bach, who remains the honorary president for life and a strong influence in IOC affairs.
4. Despite being seen as a symbol of continuity, early signs suggest she brings an independent approach to leadership.
5. Coventry's past — as a white female athlete in racially tense Zimbabwe and later a Minister in Mnangagwa's government — shapes her humane and consensual leadership style.
6. She is expected to be more inclusive and deliberate in decision-making than her predecessor.
7. Key challenges she faces include protecting female athletes, managing transgender participation in women's sports, and combating doping.
8. She must also address questions about the relevance of the Olympic movement, and how to balance traditional sports with experimental formats, like breakdancing.
9. Coventry's presidency will span critical years, including the run-up to the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.
10. She will likely interact frequently with U.S. President Donald Trump, adding a political dimension to her role.
11. Ongoing global conflicts, such as the Russia-Ukraine war and tensions in West Asia, may affect future Olympic hosting decisions, especially for 2036.
12. Russia's potential return to the Olympic Games is expected to be one of her major early decisions.
13. Countries like Qatar and Saudi Arabia, with significant financial power, are in contention to host future Games, making geopolitics central to Olympic planning.
14. India's ambitions in bidding for future Olympics also place it strategically in the spotlight, especially with support from IOC member Nita Ambani.
15. Though Coventry lacks experience in global sports administration, she is determined to navigate the complex IOC landscape and leave a strong impression.

## Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



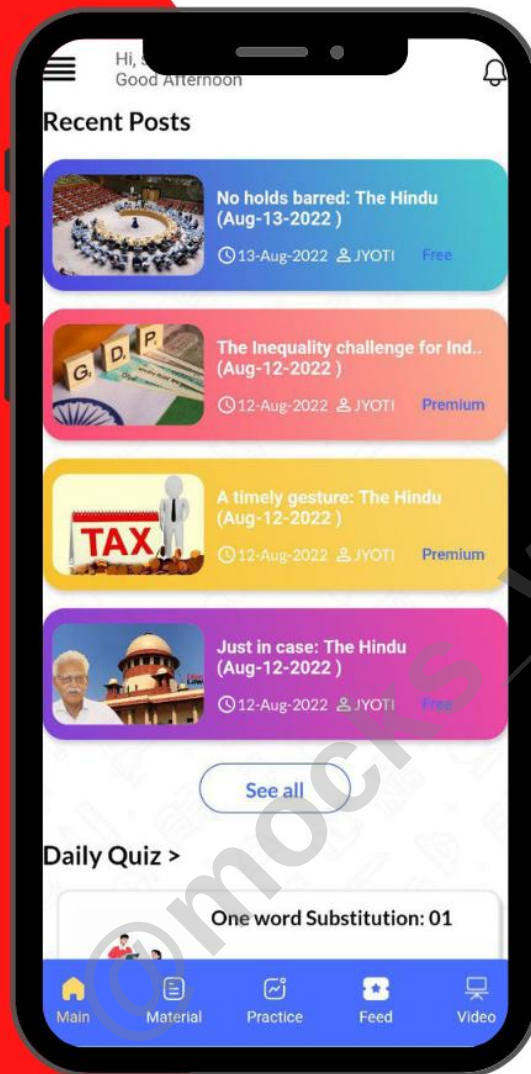
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